

Guns or Gandhi: Ethnic Elite Composition and Dissident Tactics in Civil Conflicts

Ruslan Guseinov Maaïke Arienne

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Abstract

This paper is very cool blbablablab

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Keywords: ethnic conflict, ethnic power relations, civil resistance, maximalist campaigns

Introduction

Theory & Hypotheses

Hypothesis 1. *A higher count of ethnic groups in power increases the likelihood that dissident campaigns adopt violent tactics over nonviolent tactics.*

Data and Methods

Data Description

Our study employs a panel dataset of 476 so-called “maximalist campaigns”, a concept firstly introduced by Chenoweth and Stephan in *Why Civil Resistance Works* book (Chenoweth and Stephan 2011). Following their definition, a campaign is “a series of observable, continuous, purposive mass tactics or events in pursuit of a political objective’, with maximalist objectives encompassing regime change, self-determination, secession, and the expulsion of foreign occupations (Chenoweth and Shay 2019). We rely on Nonviolent and Violent Campaigns and Outcomes (NAVCO) 2.1 dataset, which records 384 maximalist campaigns from 1945 to 2013, extended by John Chin in his dissertation to 476 campaigns - the version we use (J. J. Chin 2017).

The central conceptual distinction is between violent and nonviolent repertoires of contention. Following NAVCO coding rules, nonviolent tactics ‘do not directly threaten or harm the physical wellbeing of the regime, its agents, or its citizens’ and the violent repertoire ‘involves the use of force to physically harm or threaten to harm the opponents’ (Chenoweth and Shay 2019). The categories are mutually exclusive. A prominent example of a nonviolent campaign is the German 1989 *Die Wende* and the Cuban Revolution exemplifies a violent campaign. The violence/nonviolence distinction is well-established in the peace science literature and some significant findings have been made using NAVCO dataset (Celestino and Gleditsch 2013; Manekin and Mitts 2022; Cunningham 2013), some papers also rely on John Chin’s NAVCO 2.1 extension, which we use (J. Chin, Song, and Wright 2023). Violence is operationally coded as a binary variable (1 = a campaign take a violent form, 0 = a campaign

takes a nonviolent form).

Our key independent variables are drawn from a Ethnic Power Relations (EPR) Core Dataset (Vogt et al. 2015). EPR provides information on ethnic groups and their relative access to power. Inspired by Bivens and Thurber (2026), we focus on the Ethnic Groups in Power (EGIP) and Marginalized Ethnic Groups (MEG¹) counts. EGIP encompasses groups that exercise political power either via maintaining ethnic dominance or through power-sharing arrangements with junior partners, whilst MEG covers groups that are politically excluded from decision making, including both powerless and purposely discriminated groups. Due to theoretical expectations that a marginal effect of the ethnic groups count on the tactic choice diminishes at higher values, we apply the natural logarithm transformations to both EGIP and MEG counts in the empirical analysis.

To address endogeneity and block non-causal paths, we control for a standard set of confounders: GDP per capita in constant PPP dollars (Gapminder 2024); GDP annual growth rates; logged population size (Nations 2024); youth bulge - the proportion of young population (15-29) to the total population size; executive corruption scores (Coppedge et al. 2024); polyarchy (electoral democracy) scores (Coppedge et al. 2024); regime duration in years (Coppedge et al. 2024); peace years (years elapsed since the last maximalist campaign in each country); EGIP population share to the total population, to account for a possible confounding effect between EGIP count and a tactic choice; logged Marginalized Ethnic Groups to account for a possible confounding as well. To address reversed causality, all the independent variables are one-year lagged².

¹We also refer to MEG as “excluded groups”, these concepts are used synonymously

²Even though we find it unconvincing that a choice of one tactic over the other could anyhow affect the number of EGIP and MEG

Descriptive statistics

Table 1: Descriptive Statistics - Campaign Onset Sample

	Mean	SD	Min	Max	N
EGIP Groups (count)	2.32	3.01	0.00	15.00	467
Excluded Groups (count)	4.12	6.54	0.00	51.00	467
EGIP Population Share	0.62	0.32	0.00	1.00	467
GDP per capita (log)	8.37	0.99	5.79	11.01	448
Population (log)	9.85	1.58	5.68	13.93	439
Youth Bulge	43.74	7.39	19.86	56.56	439
GDP Growth	1.27	9.38	-51.12	82.41	448
Executive Corruption	0.62	0.24	0.01	0.98	457
Polyarchy	0.31	0.19	0.02	0.88	450
Regime Duration (log)	1.97	1.30	0.00	4.16	450
Peace Years	9.29	12.09	0.00	62.00	458

Table 1 presents descriptive statistics for all variables included in the analysis. Data missingness is not a significant issue, though for all campaigns in Yemen there is missing data on ethnic groups. Figure 1 shows the distribution of logged ethnic groups counts with respect to the tactic choice. At low EGIP and MEG counts, nonviolent tactics are more preferred and with the growing ethnic groups numbers the violent tactic is prevalent. The modal logged count is 1 - approximately 2.72 groups - for both EGIP and MEG, regardless of tactic. At higher values of both EGIP and MEG, campaigns are much more rare. This visualization shows some degree of variation 1) between violent and nonviolent choice (which is the main focus of the essay) and 2) between EGIP and MEG (which is less interesting for us).

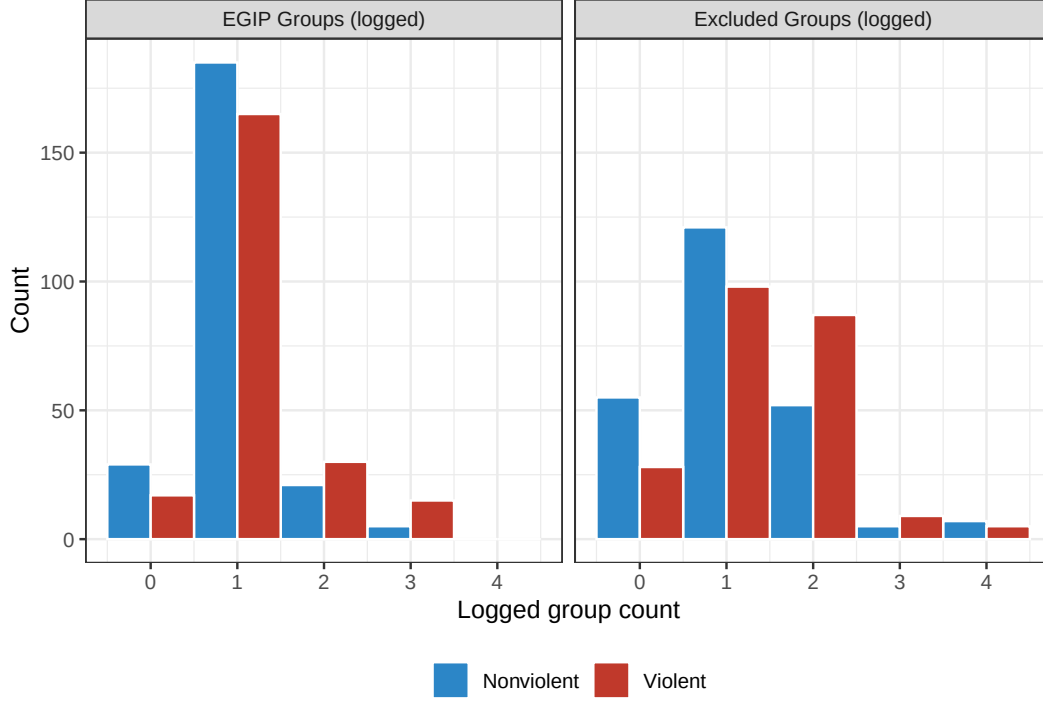


Figure 1: Ethnic Group Counts by Repertoire Choice

Modeling approach

Given a binary dependent variable and a balanced sample -232 of violent and 244 of nonviolent onsets - we estimate a logit model. As we do not predict the duration of events, there is no need for advanced binary choice models such as a complementary log-log. We also include a country fixed effect to control for the time-invariant unobserved factors (such as culture or geography).

For Hypothesis 1, our model specification is:

$$\text{violent}_{it} \sim \text{Bernoulli}(\pi_{it})$$

$$\log\left(\frac{\pi_{it}}{1 - \pi_{it}}\right) = \beta_0 + \beta_1 \ln(\text{EGIP})_{it-1} + \beta_2 \ln(\text{MEG})_{it-1} + \mathbf{X}'_{it-1}\boldsymbol{\gamma} + \alpha_i$$

where $\mathbf{X}_i$ is the vector of covariates and α_i is a country fixed effect.

For uncertainty calculations, we follow a King’s simulation approach (King, Tomz, and Wittenberg 2000). This approach is also well-established in peace science literature (Butcher and Svensson 2016). Instead of reporting coefficients and their significance, we calculate predicted probabilities as the main quantity of interest via an observed value approach (OVA), meaning we simulate the predicted probabilities for all observations and then calculate the mean of them³. For the essay, we define `sim_ova_range` function for the OVA simulations, allowing to calculate predicted probabilities in just four lines of code. It also allows for different CI levels, seeds, number of values and focal variable ranges at the researcher’s discretion.

Results

To test the first hypothesis, we estimate a logit model of the violent tactic choice, according to the H1 model specification. Figure 2 shows the simulated predicted probabilities of a violent tactic choice over a range of observed EGIP counts, with focal values exponentiated for a better interpretation. The x-axis is truncated at seven ethnic groups counts to filter out sparse data and unrealistic extrapolations. Despite a downward trend - from 0.59 at one group to 0.39 at seven groups - confidence intervals that encompass 0.5 do not allow us to claim that with the increasing number of ethnic groups in power the rebels would prefer violence over nonviolence. Instead of zero probability, our benchmark probability is approx. 0.49 - the sample proportion of violent campaigns in the whole sample.

Despite an insignificant effect of EGIP on a violent choice, the model as a whole demonstrates a strong predictive performance. We divided the dataset into a train and test sample,

³We report coefficients only in the cross-validation robustness check

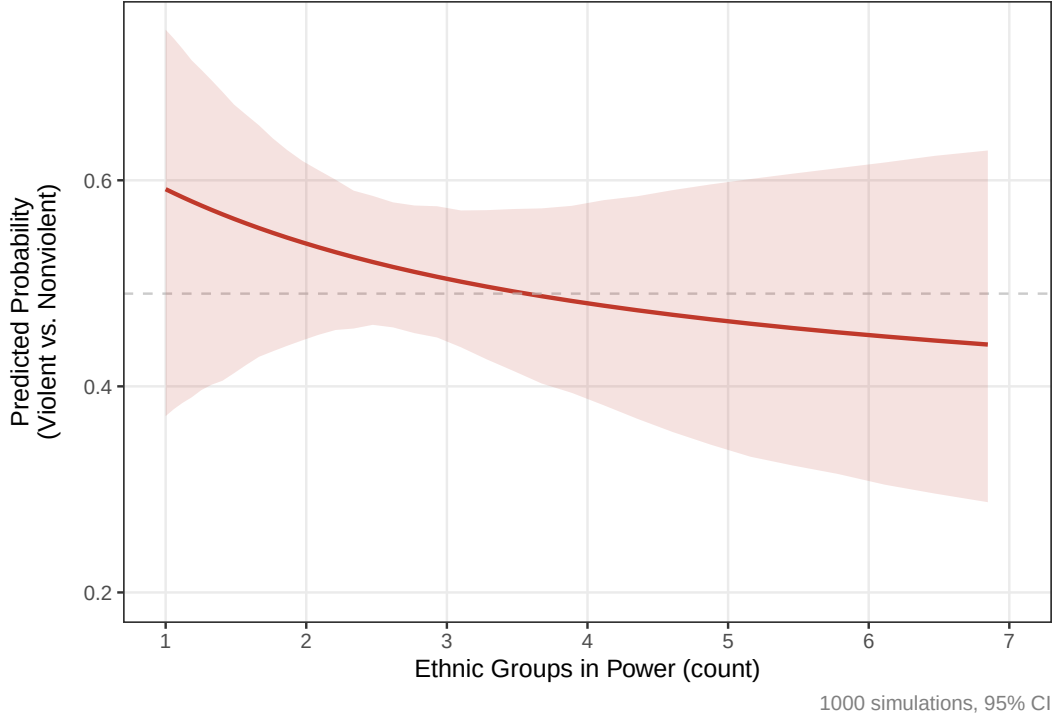


Figure 2: Simulated predicted probabilities of a violent tactic choice over a range of ethnic groups in power counts

Table 2: Confusion Matrix and Predictive Performance — Model 1

	Actual Nonviolent	Actual Violent
Confusion Matrix		
Predicted Nonviolent	47	20
Predicted Violent	10	45
Performance Metrics		
Accuracy	0.754	
Precision	0.818	
Recall	0.692	
F1 Score	0.750	

estimated a logit model on the train sample and predicted a tactic choice on the test set. Table 2 reports the confusion matrix and performance metrics. With an accuracy of 0.75 and F1 score of 0.75, our model in general predicts tactic choice well above a coin toss, predicting nonviolence a bit better than the violent choice. An important implication here is

that the model as a whole (including the specification itself, a set of covariates and a country fixed effect) captures meaningful variation in the outcome, even though the EGIP does not significantly predict a violent choice.

Robustness checks

We conduct three robustness checks. First, given that civil conflicts and a tactic choice are regionally clustered, we estimate an additional model on the Middle East and North Africa (MENA) and Sub-Saharan Africa countries subsample, where violent campaigns are more expected than in other regions. For the full sample, there are 48.7% of violent campaigns, whilst for MENA & Sub-Saharan Africa there are 58.5% of them. Second, territorial campaigns could be more ethnicity-driven and secessionist civil wars along ethnic lines are widely researched in the academic literature (Collier and Hoeffler 2006; Denny and Walter 2014; Toft 2012). For this reason, we estimated three separate models 1) on the MENA & Sub-Saharan Africa subsample, 2) excluding territorial campaigns and 3) both on the MENA & Sub-Saharan Africa sub-sample with excluded territorial campaigns.

We calculate simulated predicted probabilities over the range of EGIP counts for all three robustness check models and summarize the findings on one plot. Figure 3 shows the results along three robustness specifications, including the full-sample baseline. The only partially significant finding is in the model which excludes territorial campaigns (this subsample mostly includes anti-regime campaigns). For a low count of ethnic groups in power, campaigns that exclude territorial goals/claims have a higher chance of being nonviolent and the rebels push towards a higher likelihood of violence with the growing number of ethnic groups in power. This (though cautious) finding can be explained by the logic of mass anti-

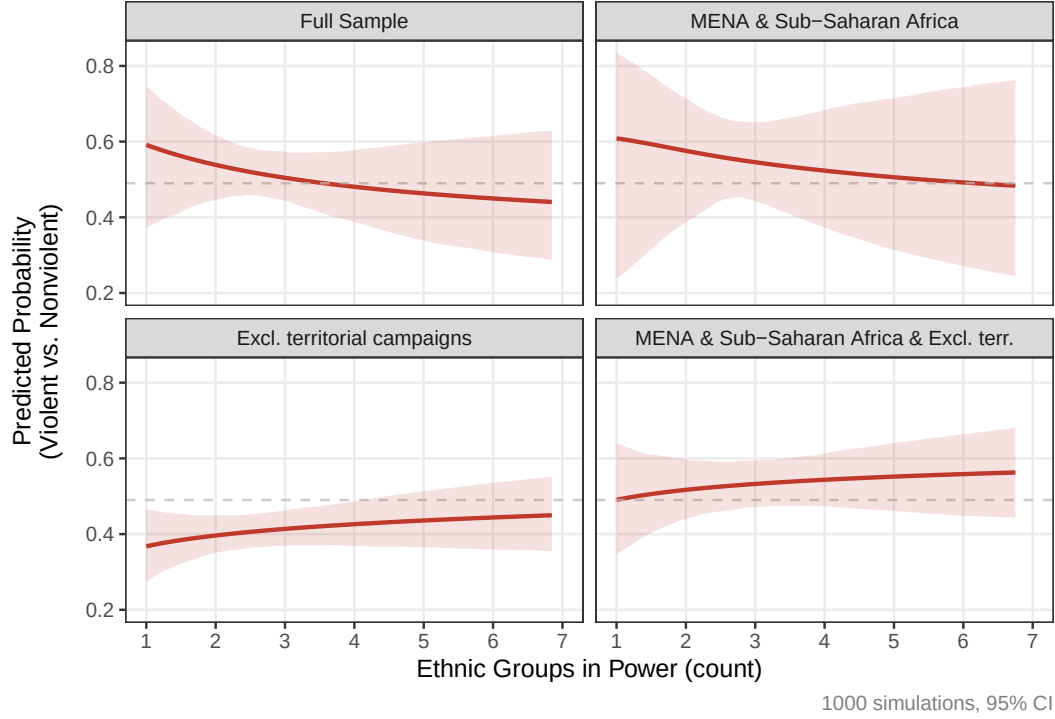


Figure 3: Simulated predicted probabilities of a violent tactic choice over a range of ethnic groups in power counts - robustness checks results

regime mobilization, where a more fragmented ethnic elite decreases the benefits of nonviolent resistance and pushes the rebels toward violent repertoires of contention. For the MENA & Sub-Saharan Africa subsample (both with and without territorial campaigns) there is no systematic difference between violence and nonviolence across the growing number of EGIP. In general, our null result is robust.

Finally, we cross-validate the results to check whether the same results hold when models are estimated on different random subsamples. For this, we define the `cross_validation_fun` function. For this part, we did not calculate quantities of interest, but rather compare coefficient values and their significance, which will be enough to judge whether the results are stable or not. Table 3 shows the coefficients differences between the main and the cross-validated model. For both models, the logged EGIP count coefficient

Table 3: Model 1: Main vs. Cross-Validated Coefficients

Variable	Main Model	Cross-Validated
ln(EGIP Groups)	-1.039 (1.211)	0.152 (2.724)
ln(Excluded Groups)	-0.022 (0.794)	-0.451 (2.297)
EGIP Population Share (ln)	0.482 (0.908)	-0.358 (2.743)
ln(GDP per capita)	-0.539 (0.791)	-0.246 (2.164)
ln(Population)	-2.911 (0.935)	-3.813 (2.466)
Youth Bulge	0.184 (0.081)	0.211 (0.162)
GDP Growth	-0.032 (0.023)	-0.053 (0.060)
Executive Corruption	1.789 (1.424)	1.964 (3.269)
Polyarchy	6.412 (1.830)	7.599 (4.166)
ln(Regime Duration)	-0.444 (0.190)	-0.346 (0.328)
Peace Years	0.030 (0.018)	0.025 (0.041)

Note: Intercept is not reported. Standard errors in parentheses. Cross-validated SE via King (2001) combination rule.

is negative and insignificant, though the coefficient absolute values differ. Moreover, one could notice the inflation of the standard errors, suggesting the results are not as robust as expected. However, the reader should account for the sample size and respective test sample sizes that partly explain standard errors' inflation.

Discussion

Conclusion

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